The Frog Prince

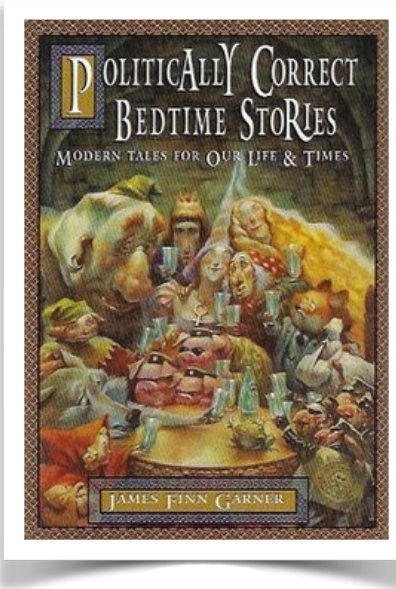
James Finn Garner

James Finn Garner (born 1960)



James Finn Garner (born 1960) is an American author, humorist, and satirist based in Chicago, USA. He is best known for his bestselling collection *Politically Correct Bedtime Stories* (1994), which humorously rewrites traditional fairy tales from a modern perspective. His other notable works include *Politically Correct Holiday Stories*, *Apocalypse Wow*, *Once Upon a More Enlightened Time*, and *Recut Madness*. Garner's writing combines wit, parody, and satire to challenge social stereotypes, cultural assumptions, and the excesses of political correctness, encouraging readers to think critically while being entertained.

About the Book and the Tale



Politically Correct Bedtime Stories: Modern Tales for Our Life and Times (1994) is a humorous collection by James Finn Garner. In this book, Garner rewrites well-known fairy tales using satire and parody to question traditional ideas about gender, politics, society, and environmental issues. By exaggerating the concept of political correctness, he encourages readers to think critically about the values and stereotypes found in classic children's stories.

The Frog Prince is one of the most popular stories in the collection. It is a modern adaptation of the traditional fairy tale made famous by the Grimm Brothers. Instead of a handsome prince, Garner presents a greedy real estate developer who plans to destroy a forest for commercial gain. Through humour, irony, and an unexpected ending, the story critiques patriarchy, environmental exploitation, and corporate greed while challenging the conventions of traditional fairy tales.

“The Frog Prince” text

Once there was a young princess who, when she grew tired of beating her head against the male power structure at her castle, would relax by walking into the woods and sitting beside a small pond. There she would amuse herself by tossing her favorite golden ball up and down and pondering the role of the eco-feminist warrior in her era.



One day, while she was envisioning the utopia that her queendom could become if womyn were in the positions of power, she dropped the ball, which rolled into the pond. The pond was so deep and murky she couldn't see where it had gone. She didn't cry, of course, but she made a mental note to be more careful next time.

Suddenly she heard a voice say, "I can get your ball for you, princess."

She looked around, and saw the head of a frog popping above the surface of the pond. "No, no," she said, "I would never enslave a member of another species to work for my selfish desires." The frog said, "Well, what if we make a deal on a contingency basis? I'll get your ball for you if you do me a favor in return.”

The princess gladly agreed to this most equitable arrangement. The frog dived under the water and soon emerged with the golden ball in his mouth. He spit the ball on the shore and said, "Now that I've done you a favor, I'd like to explore your views on physical attraction between the species."

The princess couldn't imagine what the frog was talking about. The frog continued, "You see, I am not really a frog at all. I'm really a man, but an evil sorcerer has cast a spell on me. While my frog form is no better or worse – only different – than my human form, I would so much like to be among people again. And the only thing that can break this spell is a kiss from a princess.”

The princess thought for a moment about whether sexual harassment could take place between species, but her heart went out to the frog for his predicament. She bent down and kissed the frog on the forehead. Instantly the frog grew and changed. And there, standing in the water where the frog had been, was a man in a golf shirt and loud plaid pants – middle-aged, vertically challenged, and losing a little bit of hair on top.

The princess was taken aback. "I'm sorry if this sounds a little classist," she stammered, "but… what I mean to say is… don't sorcerers usually cast their spells on *princes*?”

"Ordinarily, yes," he said, "but this time the target was just an innocent businessman. You see, I'm a real estate developer, and the sorcerer thought I was cheating him in a property-line dispute. So he invited me out for a round of golf, and just as I was about to tee off, he transformed me. But my time as a frog wasn't wasted, you know. I've gotten to know every square inch of these woods, and I think it would be ideal for an office park/condo/resort complex. The location's great and the numbers crunch perfectly! The bank wouldn't lend any money to a frog, but now that I'm in human form again, they'll be eating out of my hand. Oh, will that be sweet! And let me tell you, this is going to be a big project! Just drain the pond, cut down about 80 percent of the trees, get easements for…"

The frog developer was cut short when the princess shoved her golden ball back into his mouth. She then pushed him back underwater and held him there until he stopped thrashing. As she walked back to the castle, she marveled at the number of good deeds that a person could do in just one morning. And while someone might have noticed that the frog was gone, no one ever missed the real estate developer.

Summary of Garner's Story

The story features a princess who is intelligent, independent, and deeply concerned about women's rights and environmental protection. When her golden ball falls into a pond, she refuses to make the frog retrieve it out of respect for another species. The frog offers to help in return for a favour and later reveals that he is actually a man who has been transformed by a sorcerer. After the princess kisses him, the spell is broken. However, instead of becoming a noble prince, he turns into a greedy real estate developer who plans to drain the pond, cut down the surrounding forest, and build a commercial resort. Horrified by his plans to destroy nature, the princess pushes him back into the pond and drowns him. The story ends with the princess believing she has protected the environment by stopping his destructive ambitions.

Summary of the Traditional/Original Story

In the traditional version of *The Frog Prince*, popularized by the Grimm Brothers, a princess loses her golden ball in a well. A frog retrieves it in return for her companionship. Although she breaks her promise, her father compels her to honour it. Eventually, the frog transforms into a handsome prince, and they marry happily. The tale teaches the importance of keeping promises, showing kindness, and not judging others by their appearance.

Comparison with the Original Tale

Traditional Story	Garner's Version
Passive princess	Independent eco-feminist
Handsome prince	Middle-aged real estate developer
Wicked witch	Evil sorcerer
Marriage	Death
Happy ending	Dark comic ending

Moral about promises	Critique of capitalism and environmental destruction

Garner deliberately reverses readers' expectations.

The familiar fairy-tale ending is replaced by a shocking conclusion that forces readers to rethink the assumptions behind traditional stories.

Satire and Parody

James Finn Garner employs **satire** and **parody** as the two principal literary devices in “The Frog Prince.” Through satire, he uses humour, irony, and exaggeration to criticize social issues such as patriarchy, environmental exploitation, and corporate greed, encouraging readers to question accepted beliefs. At the same time, the story functions as a parody of the traditional Grimm Brothers' fairy tale. By rewriting the familiar narrative in unexpected and humorous ways, Garner entertains readers while offering a sharp commentary on modern society and cultural values.

Understanding Political Correctness

In *The Frog Prince*, James Finn Garner explores the idea of **political correctness**, which promotes language and behaviour that avoid offending or excluding others based on gender, race, religion, disability, sexuality, or the environment. Garner humorously exaggerates these ideas to comic extremes, creating a satirical effect. Rather than simply supporting political correctness, he critiques both the stereotypes found in traditional fairy tales and the excesses of politically correct thinking. As a result, the story encourages readers to reflect critically on both old prejudices and modern social attitudes.

Major Themes in “The Frog Prince”

1. Feminism

One of the central themes of the story is **feminism**. Unlike the passive and helpless princess in the traditional fairy tale, Garner's princess is intelligent, politically aware, environmentally conscious, and independent. She makes her own decisions and does not depend on a prince or her father for protection. Significantly, the king is absent from the story, symbolizing a rejection of patriarchal authority and traditional gender roles.

2. Ecofeminism

The story also explores **ecofeminism**, which argues that the oppression of women and the exploitation of nature are closely connected. The princess sees herself as an eco-feminist and values the natural world. In contrast, the transformed frog, now a real estate developer, plans to drain the pond, cut down trees, and build commercial properties. By killing him, the princess protects nature from destruction and reinforces the ecofeminist message of the story.

3. Capitalism and Corporate Greed

Garner criticizes **capitalism and corporate greed** through the character of the real estate developer. Instead of becoming a noble prince, the frog turns into a businessman interested only in profit. His plans to destroy forests and wetlands for commercial development show how modern capitalism often values economic gain over environmental conservation. The story condemns the reckless exploitation of nature for financial benefit.

4. Political Correctness

The theme of **political correctness** runs throughout the story. The characters use exaggerated politically correct language, such as refusing to "enslave another species," speaking of equality, and replacing "kingdom" with "queendom" and "women" with "womyn." Garner humorously exaggerates these expressions to satirize both traditional stereotypes and the excesses of politically correct language.

5. Subversion of Fairy-Tale Conventions

Garner deliberately **subverts the conventions of the traditional fairy tale**. Instead of a prince rescuing the princess and ending the story with marriage and happiness, he presents environmental activism, corporate greed, irony, and even death. By replacing romance with social criticism, Garner transforms a familiar fairy tale into a modern satire that encourages readers to question accepted social values and literary traditions.

Literary Techniques

James Finn Garner employs several literary techniques to enhance the story's humour and social criticism. **Irony** is evident when the expected handsome prince turns out to be a greedy real estate developer. **Humour** arises from the exaggerated use of politically correct language and situations. The story also makes effective use of **symbolism**: the **golden ball** represents traditional fairy-tale ideals, the **pond** symbolizes nature, the **real estate developer** represents uncontrolled capitalism, and the **princess** symbolizes feminism and environmental consciousness.

Significance of the Story

The story shows that folklore evolves with changing times and values. While traditional fairy tales celebrate romance and monarchy, Garner's version addresses contemporary issues such as gender equality, environmental protection, political correctness, consumerism, and corporate exploitation. As a result, the story serves not only as entertaining fiction but also as a powerful work of social satire.

Multiple Choice Questions

1. James Finn Garner's “The Frog Prince” is a modern retelling of the fairy tale originally popularized by:

A. Hans Christian Andersen
B. Charles Perrault
C. The Grimm Brothers
D. Lewis Carroll

2. In Garner's version of the story, the princess is portrayed as:

A. Helpless and dependent on the prince
B. Intelligent, independent, and eco-feminist
C. A selfish and spoiled royal child
D. A powerless victim of the sorcerer

3. After the spell is broken, the frog is transformed into:

A. A handsome prince
B. A brave knight
C. A wealthy merchant
D. A greedy real estate developer

4. Which of the following themes is most strongly represented by the transformed frog's plan to drain the pond and cut down the forest?

A. Romantic love
B. Capitalism and corporate greed
C. Friendship and loyalty
D. Religious faith

5. Which literary devices are most prominently used by James Finn Garner in “The Frog Prince?”

A. Allegory and epic
B. Satire and parody
C. Tragedy and realism
D. Myth and legend

6. What is the main purpose of Garner's retelling of “The Frog Prince?”

A. To preserve the traditional fairy tale without any changes
B. To celebrate monarchy and royal traditions
C. To entertain readers while criticizing modern social issues and traditional stereotypes
D. To provide a historical account of medieval Europe

Answer Keys

1. C; 2. B; 3. D; 4. B; 5. B; 6. C.

Short Answer Questions

1. How does James Finn Garner portray the princess differently from the traditional fairy-tale princess?
Hint: *Independent; eco-feminist; politically aware.*

2. Why does the princess kill the transformed frog at the end of the story?
Hint: *Environmental protection; corporate greed.*

3. Explain the significance of the real estate developer in the story.
Hint: *Capitalism; environmental exploitation.*

4. How does “The Frog Prince” function as a parody of the traditional Grimm Brothers' fairy tale?
Hint: *Modern retelling; reversal of expectations; satire.*

5. Discuss any two major themes in “The Frog Prince.”
Hint: *Feminism; ecofeminism; political correctness; corporate greed.*

Essay Questions

1. Discuss how James Finn Garner transforms the traditional fairy tale “The Frog Prince” into a modern social satire.

Hint: Compare Garner's version with the Grimm Brothers' tale; discuss the independent princess, the real estate developer, parody, satire, irony, environmental concerns, and the subversion of the traditional happy ending.

2. Examine the major themes in “The Frog Prince.” How does Garner use the story to comment on contemporary society?

Hint: Discuss feminism, ecofeminism, capitalism and corporate greed, political correctness, and the subversion of fairy-tale conventions with relevant examples from the story.

3. Analyse the use of satire, parody, irony, and symbolism in James Finn Garner's “The Frog Prince.” How do these literary techniques strengthen the story's social criticism?

Hint: Explain satire and parody as the principal techniques; discuss irony (the prince becomes a developer) and symbolism (golden ball, pond, princess, real estate developer); show how these devices criticize traditional stereotypes and modern social issues.